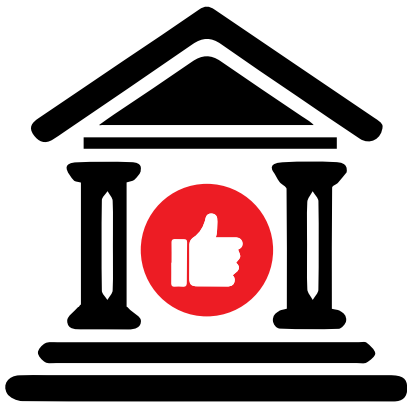




BANKING ON THE BEST

THE BANKING SECTOR has posted a strong performance in the first quarter of FY23 on the back of robust growth and improving asset quality. Consider this: ICICI Bank, the country's second-biggest private sector lender, has registered a 50 per cent year-on-year (YoY) rise in profit after tax at ₹6,905 crore as against ₹4,616 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. Similarly, IndusInd Bank and Axis Bank have also posted jumps of 61 per cent and 91 per cent in net profit at ₹1,603.29 crore and ₹4,125 crore in the first quarter, respectively, mainly due to a fall in bad loans.

—TEENA JAIN KAUSHAL

RAY OF HOPE FOR PAYTM?

Global and domestic institutional investors turned gung-ho on the stock of beaten-down Paytm's parent One 97 Communications in the June quarter. Latest shareholding data with the BSE show that FIIs upped their stake to 5.45 per cent in the company from 4.42 per cent on March 31. Likewise, MFs raised their holdings to 1.14 per cent from 1.05 per cent in the same period. On July 27, shares of the company traded at ₹713.65, down nearly 67 per cent, against the issue price of ₹2,150. Is there light at the end of the tunnel?

—RAHUL OBEROI

COMMODITY PRICES COOLING

After scaling new heights in the first half of 2022, prices of key agri-commodities are expected to fall and bring relief to consumers. In fact, the price of palm oil has already halved in the international market. This, coupled with softening prices of crude oil and a normal monsoon in India, is bringing down the cost of packaging and logistics, apart from raising hopes of a better crop yield. As packaged food majors are planning to increase grammage, experts anticipate the return of a volume-led growth cycle in the second half of FY23.

—ARNAB DUTTA



THE NEXT GENERATION

The auction of 5G telecom spectrum—which concluded recently—has yielded the government over ₹1.5 lakh crore. In a process spread over a week and after 40 rounds, it emerged that Reliance Jio had spent the most at ₹88,078 crore to pick up airwaves, which includes the expensive 700 MHz band, followed by Bharti Airtel (₹43,084 crore) and Vodafone Idea (₹18,799 crore). For the consumer, access to 5G translates to better voice and data services. The bigger question is how much the customer will pay on the back of companies having coughed up such large amounts. Companies are expected to launch 5G services by October.

—KRISHNA GOPALAN



The Coming Gig Wave

THE NITI AAYOG, the government's think tank, says the country's gig workforce is expected to shoot up to 23.5 million by 2029-30, from 7.7 million in FY21. At present, around 47 per cent of the gig work is in medium-skilled jobs, 22 per cent are in high-skilled ones, while low-skilled jobs make up the balance, says the report, titled 'India's Booming Gig and Platform Economy'. It adds that the trend shows that the concentration of workers with medium skills is declining gradually, while that of those with low skills and high skills is increasing. "It may be expected that while the domination of medium skills would continue till 2030, gig work with other skills will emerge," the report says.

—RAHUL OBEROI



THE AVERAGE RISE IN INCOME OF FARMERS ACROSS INDIA BETWEEN FY18-FY22, AS PER SBI. IN SOME CROPS LIKE SOYBEAN IN MAHARASHTRA AND COTTON IN KARNATAKA, INCOMES HAVE DOUBLED DURING THE SAME PERIOD